

STRATEGY BLUEPRINT

When the CRM owns the process

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THE SITUATION

Sales and delivery were supposed to run in the CRM. Over time the CRM's fields and stages became the process, whether or not that matched how the team actually wins and delivers work. A portal for clients or partners was bolted on. Integrations keep multiplying (finance, email, quoting, project tools). On paper the stack looks connected. In practice the team still chases truth in spreadsheets and inbox, and every new "fix" means another brittle join to a system that was never designed for this business.

PROBLEMS IT CAUSES

- Stages in the CRM do not match real client journeys, so people work around the tool instead of in it.
- The portal cannot show a trustworthy picture because the CRM is the wrong source of truth.
- Integration count rises while cycle time, forecast confidence, and handoff quality stay flat or worsen.
- Reporting takes days of reconciliation between CRM, sheets, and email.
- Changing a price book, stage, or delivery workflow requires vendor workarounds or shadow process.
- New hires inherit "ask Sarah" and "check the other sheet" as operating procedure.
- Leadership cannot tell whether growth is blocked by market or by tooling that will not flex.

WHY THE USUAL FIXES FAIL

Buying a newer CRM usually means reshaping the business again to fit a different vendor model. Adding more integrations deepens dependence on the wrong centre. Rebuilding only the portal leaves the broken core untouched. A big transformation programme arrives late and expensive for a problem that needs a clear spine first.

THE PATH FORWARD

Keep what still earns its keep. Integrate on purpose. Replace the wrong centre. Useful with or without FluentForward.

- 01 Map the real journey: how a lead or job actually moves from first contact to delivered and paid, including the unofficial steps.
- 02 Write down where truth lives today for stage, owner, price, and status (CRM field, sheet, inbox, portal, someone's head).
- 03 Decide the spine: the few objects and stages the business must share (for example client, opportunity, job, quote) in language the ops team already uses.
- 04 Keep the CRM only for what it still does well (for example email sync, basic contact store, or a reporting export regulators expect), or plan a clean exit if it does none of that well.
- 05 Stop treating the CRM as the process engine if it cannot hold your real stages without fighting you.
- 06 Design one owned system of record for the spine: the place operators open for "where is this work and who owns it."
- 07 Re-home the portal so it reads and writes against that spine, not against a vendor schema that forces workarounds.
- 08 Integrate outward on purpose: finance, identity, file store, messaging, only where a join removes a handoff, not to recreate the old spaghetti.
- 09 Cut or freeze integrations that only exist to paper over CRM gaps.
- 10 Ship a first release that covers the busiest path end to end (even if other paths stay manual for a sprint).
- 11 Move the remaining edge cases onto the spine in order of pain, with a backlog the business can see.
- 12 Put ownership with the firm: access, change control, and the ability to evolve stages without a vendor ticket.

WHAT GOOD LOOKS LIKE

Operators stop bending the week around the CRM. The portal and integrations serve a process you recognise. Leadership sees one live picture of the book. The firm owns the system that runs the work. Finance and leadership stop waiting on a reconciliation week. Client-facing portals stop lying because they finally read the same spine the team uses. Changing a stage or price book becomes a controlled change you own, not a vendor ticket and a shadow sheet.

EXAMPLE FIRST RELEASE (ABOUT 8 WEEKS)

FluentForward’s focused delivery shape for this problem. Business milestones, not the full path list.

Weeks 1-2	Map how sell and deliver actually move; name the spine (client, opportunity, job, quote); decide what the CRM keeps, what integrates, and what it must stop owning.
Weeks 3-4	Design the owned first release for the busiest path; agree which CRM jobs stay satellite; plan how the portal re-homes onto the spine.
Weeks 5-7	Build the spine operators open daily; wire essential joins only; shadow-run beside the old CRM path where risk is high.
Week 8	Go-live on that path; demote or narrow the CRM for those flows; short adoption note; backlog for the next journeys.

ONE LINE A PEER CAN FORWARD

“We stopped adding integrations to a CRM that fought our process, and put an owned system at the centre of how we actually sell and deliver.”